Sunsama: Done for the Day

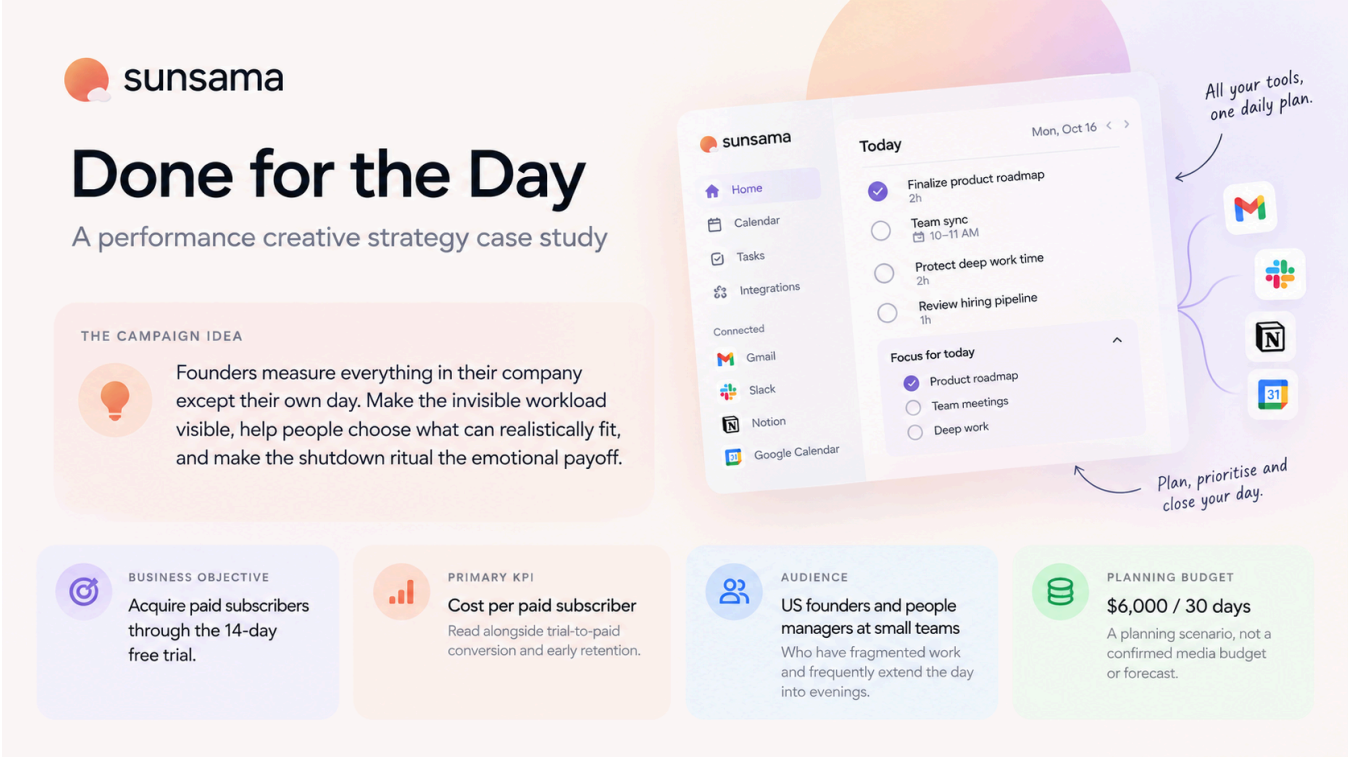
Oct 23, 2026 · @Richa

Sunsama · Independent performance creative case study ·

Six hours of meetings walk into a nine-hour to-do list

Founders track revenue, churn, burn and hiring pipeline to the decimal. Ask them how many hours today actually has, and they'll guess.

I believe that's the whole opportunity. **Founders measure everything in their company except their own day.** So the campaign makes the invisible workload visible, helps them choose what can realistically fit, and makes the shutdown ritual the emotional payoff.



Project status. An independent speculative concept for my portfolio. It wasn't commissioned, approved or run by Sunsama; no ads were launched and no budget was spent. I've written it the way I'd pitch it from inside Sunsama's growth team: that's a voice, not a claim to work there.

Process note. AI tools supported parts of the research and drafting. The strategic framing, creative direction and final decisions are mine.

Decision	Recommendation

Business objective	Acquire paid subscribers through the 14-day free trial
Primary business KPI	Cost per paid subscriber, read alongside trial-to-paid conversion and early retention
Leading quality KPI	Cost per activated trial; proposed activation = at least 3 daily plans in the first 7 days
Audience	US founders and people managers at small teams, with fragmented work that often spills into evenings
Campaign	Done for the Day: make realistic capacity and a deliberate finish line the story
Plan	$6,000 over 30 days, as a planning scenario, not a confirmed budget or forecast

Decision	Recommendation
Evidence labels	**Verified:** supported by a cited source. **Observed:** visible in public creative or firsthand material. **Interpretation:** my strategic reading. **Hypothesis:** a claim the campaign must test

Executive summary

Sunsama isn't selling another place to store your tasks. It's selling a more intentional relationship with work: plan around the hours you actually have, decide what matters, and end the day on purpose.

So the moment I'd dramatise is the one just before that finish line. The task list is longer than the day, and something has to give.

My lead concept, **The Math**, makes that mismatch impossible to ignore: six hours of meetings plus nine hours of tasks don't fit into a normal workday. The product demo doesn't pretend they do. It shows the user prioritising and deferring work, making the trade-off instead of hoping for a miracle. Then the ad ends on the shutdown ritual.

"Done for the Day" isn't new whitespace. Sunsama already talks about shutdown rituals, realistic planning and work-life boundaries in its ads. My idea is to show the *decision* that makes shutdown possible: see the day's real capacity, defer lower-priority work, then close the loop.

Business and product context

What Sunsama sells

Sunsama is a guided daily planner that brings tasks and calendar commitments into one realistic plan. Its philosophy is that work should be fulfilling and sustainable, not an endless efficiency contest.

- **Daily planning:** collect work, prioritise, and plan against available time.
- **Calendar and task integration:** pull work from Gmail, Slack, Notion, Trello and Asana into one daily view.
- **Shutdown ritual:** review the day, prepare for tomorrow, and signal that work is finished.

Trial and pricing

Sunsama's billing documentation lists a 14-day trial with no card needed. Pricing is $22 a month billed monthly, or $204 a year upfront (about $17 a month). I'd recheck both before publishing, because pricing changes.

Commercial fact	Creative implication
14-day trial; no card required	A low-friction CTA, but trial starts alone don't prove value
$22 monthly / $204 annual upfront	The ad has to demonstrate a useful behaviour, not just claim productivity

The business problem

A free calendar shows appointments. A task list stores work. Neither resolves the tension between the hours available and the obligations coming in. The campaign has to make Sunsama feel materially different from yet another list: it helps a person decide what fits, what moves, and when to stop.

Problem definition

You can be busy all day and still end it feeling behind.

Meetings break up focus. Slack resets priorities every hour. The work you meant to do slides into the evening. And because nobody decided what mattered most, everything feels unfinished.

Here's my reframe: the problem isn't that founders need to work faster. It's that their plan never admitted how many hours the day actually has.

The moment it becomes visible

Picture a day with six hours of meetings and nine hours of tasks (illustrative numbers, not Sunsama user data). A normal to-do list leaves that contradiction sitting there, unresolved. My creative shows the user making it visible, choosing what matters, moving lower-priority work, and closing the day on purpose.

Symptom	Underlying tension	Creative opportunity
A full calendar plus an even longer list	The plan assumes more capacity than exists	Show the math before showing the product

Symptom	Underlying tension	Creative opportunity
Reactive work crowds out priorities	Urgency replaces intention	Make the user choose what matters today
Work continues after the laptop closes	There's no psychological finish line	Make shutdown the campaign's recurring end frame

Evidence and caveat. Sunsama's 2025 State of Modern Work and Well-being report describes fragmented focus, always-on pressure and workload overwhelm among its respondents. It's useful for spotting a relevant problem, but it's brand-published research with Sunsama customers and alumni, not a representative picture of all knowledge workers. Its correlations aren't causal proof.

Audience and persona

I'd build this for founders and people managers at small US teams: high responsibility, fragmented work, and a constant tug-of-war between meetings and focused work.

Persona: Daniel, 36

An illustrative composite for creative planning, not a real customer or research participant.

Demographics. Daniel is 36 and co-founded a 12-person software company in Denver four years ago. He has a technical background, a partner, a young kid, and a commute he mostly spends on calls. He runs product and hiring, and still writes the occasional spec himself.

How his day works. Meetings fill his calendar until mid-afternoon. His tasks live across Slack, Linear, email and a paper notebook, on top of Google Calendar and a task tool. Focused work starts late and spills into the evening, and he often ends the day unsure what actually moved forward.

Psychographics. He's data-driven about the business and oddly vague about his own time. He feels guilty logging off with things undone, and guiltier still when work eats family evenings. He's sceptical of productivity hype and "perfect founder" content, and trusts tools that prove themselves in the first week, not the first month.

What he wants: to protect time for high-value work and stop at a chosen hour, without carrying an open mental list to bed.

What triggers the search: a week of late nights, a calendar packed with meetings, a new management responsibility, or an important project slipping.

His objection: "I already have a calendar and a task manager. Why pay for another tool?"

Motivations to test

- **Control:** I want to choose the day's priorities instead of reacting to every new request.
- **Relief:** I want to finish work with a clear plan for what remains.
- **Practical proof:** I need to see how the product changes my planning behaviour.

What this means for the message. No generic wellness language and no idealised founder imagery. Show a credible, busy person making one trade-off, and bring the product in early enough that the ad doesn't drift into a vague work-life balance promise.

Competitive and creative audit

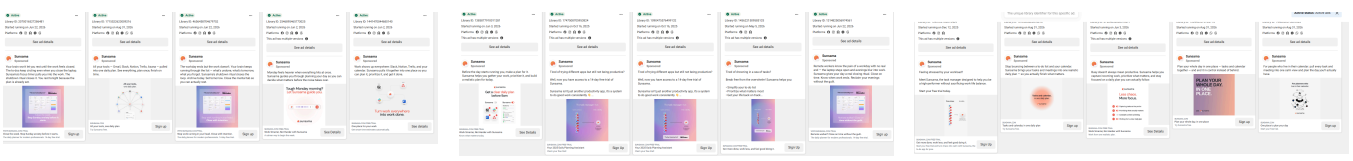
Category patterns

Brand	Observed lead	Implication for this campaign
Motion	AI-powered scheduling, auto-rescheduling and protecting time for deep work	Automation, and letting the system arrange your work, are loud category cues
Akiflow	A unified task inbox, calendar, time blocking and fast planning across tools	Control and speed across a fragmented workflow are loud cues too
Sunsama	Intentional daily planning, realistic workload decisions and shutdown rituals	The product already owns a deliberate finish line; the campaign can dramatise the decision that comes before it

A directional mini-audit of public product messaging, not a spend or performance analysis. It doesn't prove competitors never talk about calm, capacity or shutdown.

Sunsama Meta Ad Library snapshots

Captured in October 2026. Messaging and visual choices only, not performance.



[Figure 1: daily planning before the day starts running you]

[Figure 2: task manager positioning and the "chaos into clarity" promise]

[Figure 3: workload overwhelm and simplification framing]

Creative pattern read

Pattern observed	What it signals	What my concept should do
Plan before the day starts	Prevention and intentionality	Show the plan confronting actual capacity
Chaos → clarity	Emotional transformation	Make the transformation concrete through one visible trade-off
Overwhelm and too many tasks	Recognition of the pain	Don't just restate overwhelm; show a mechanism
Shutdown / close the loop	A clear end state and brand ritual	Keep shutdown as the repeated final frame
Integrations and one view	Practical consolidation	A supporting concept, not the lead story

What the audit tells me. Our edge isn't the territory, it's the sequence: expose the mismatch, make the trade-off, *then* earn the shutdown.

Strategic synthesis

Core insight: founders measure everything in their company (revenue, churn, burn rate, hiring pipeline) except their own day. Without a finish line, work doesn't end. It just stops when they run out of energy.

Campaign platform: Done for the Day.

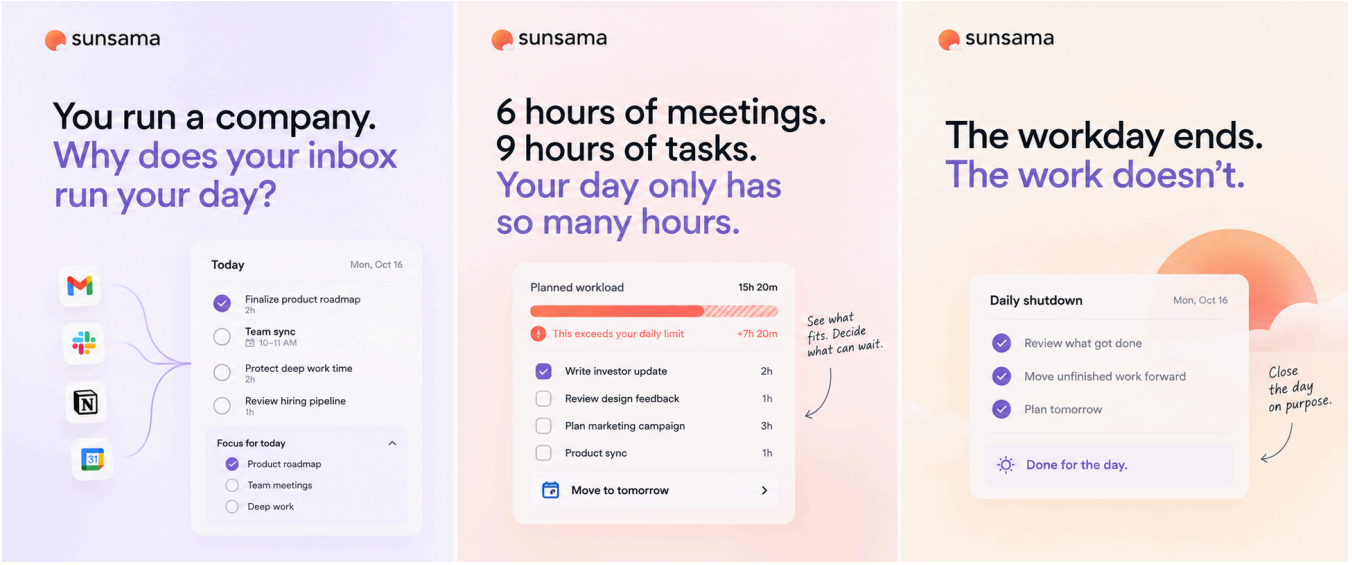
Campaign line: "Run the company. Don't let the day run you."

Strategic choice	Why I made it
Audience: founders and managers	High responsibility, fragmented work, and a clear tension between meetings and focused work
Lead angle: workload math	Concrete and demonstrable; far less interchangeable than a general promise to feel productive
Emotional payoff: shutdown	Connects practical planning to the feeling of finishing deliberately
Proof style: product demo	Makes the mechanism visible and answers the "another task manager?" objection

Creative rules

- Show the product doing the work in every ad. No abstract productivity imagery.
- Speak like a founder: meetings, priorities, the team, and the work only they can do.
- Aspirational, not smug. The person is busy, not perfect.
- Label every illustrative number and concept UI. Never imply a projection is an observed result.
- Use the real product interface in final production wherever possible; any reconstructed UI here is a concept visualisation.

Creative concepts



presentation purposes]

Three static ads, each betting on a different reason founders might care, all built on Sunsama's logo, restrained pastels, generous whitespace and one idea per ad.

The Founder's Day

Founder identity and control · Cold audience → trial

> **ON IMAGE** You run a company. Why does your inbox run your day?
>
> **PRIMARY TEXT** The best leaders don't work longer. They decide what today is for. Sunsama brings your calendar and tasks into one plan you can actually finish.
>
> **HEADLINE** End the day on purpose **CTA** Start free trial

Why this ad? Founders often let incoming messages and team requests dictate their day, leaving little room for strategic work. This concept tests whether a founder-identity hook resonates more strongly than a feature-led message. It positions Sunsama as a way to plan around priorities rather than react to everyone else's.

Visual direction. Use Sunsama's minimal, pastel brand language. Show the Sunsama logo, connected work tools such as Gmail, Slack, Notion and Google Calendar, and a daily planning interface. The integrations should lead visually into one organised daily plan. Use accurate product captures where possible; any reconstructed interface is illustrative.

The Math

Practical problem-solving · Cold audience → trial

> **ON IMAGE** 6 hours of meetings. 9 hours of tasks. Your day only has so many hours.
>
> **PRIMARY TEXT** Most to-do lists pretend you have unlimited hours. Sunsama helps you see what fits, decide what can wait, and plan a day that doesn't spill into your evening.
>
> **HEADLINE** Plan a day that actually fits **CTA** Start free trial

Why this ad? Founders can have a calendar full of meetings and a task list that assumes the rest of the day is available. This concept makes that contradiction tangible and tests whether showing the workload problem can generate more qualified trial starts than a broad productivity promise. The numbers are illustrative, not customer data.

Visual direction. Show a daily plan with an overloaded workload indicator and a clear option to move lower-priority work to tomorrow. Keep the headline dominant and the product interface as supporting proof. Label illustrative hours and reconstructed UI clearly.

The Finish Line

Emotional relief and workday closure · Cold audience → trial

> **ON IMAGE** The workday ends. The work doesn't.
>
> **PRIMARY TEXT** When you run a company, there's always something left to do. Sunsama helps you plan your priorities, prepare for tomorrow, and close the day on purpose.
>
> **HEADLINE** Close the day on purpose **CTA** Start free trial

Why this ad? Founders may struggle to stop working because unfinished tasks make the day feel incomplete. This concept builds on Sunsama's existing workday-closure messaging and tests whether the desire to finish intentionally motivates interest in the product's daily planning and shutdown ritual.

Visual direction. Show the Sunsama daily shutdown experience, including reviewing completed work, moving unfinished tasks forward and preparing for tomorrow. End the visual hierarchy on the "Done for the day" state. Keep the design calm, minimal and product-led.

Supporting concept: One Plan, Not Another List

"Your work lives in five places. Your day still only has one calendar." Show tasks and meetings brought into one daily plan. It's a useful secondary angle, but I wouldn't lead the first test with it: integration claims alone can make Sunsama look like just another

aggregator, not a tool for making realistic decisions.

Testing framework

I want the first test to answer one question, and only one: which founder problem framing attracts trial users who go on to form a daily planning habit?

Test	Hypothesis	Main variable	Primary read
A: The Founder's Day vs The Math vs The Finish Line	Founder identity, workload realism and workday closure may attract different levels of qualified interest	Core message and its product visual	Cost per activated trial, with trial-start cost as an early signal
B: Hook iteration	The strongest concept may improve with a sharper headline or opening visual	Headline or first visual, tested separately	Outbound CTR, trial-start rate and activation quality
C: Product visual iteration	A clearer product demo may improve understanding and trial quality	Product UI visual, with the message held constant	Cost per activated trial and activation rate
D: Integration angle (later)	Tool consolidation may appeal to founders tired of fragmented workflows	The secondary message	Trial quality, not clicks

What stays steady: audience, trial offer, CTA, landing page, placements and comparable visual quality. One major variable changes at a time, with consistent UTMs for campaign, ad, creative version and landing page.

Budget logic. The $6,000 over 30 days is a planning scenario, not a confirmed budget or a guaranteed sample size. I'd split the first test budget across the three concepts, then reserve spend for iterating the most promising one.

30-day testing timeline

A proposed sequence, not a historical one.

Days	Work	Decision or output
1–4	Finalise the three concepts. Capture accurate product UI, confirm claims, and QA UTMs and trial tracking	Three launch-ready statics and a measurement checklist
5–11	Test all three under consistent audience, offer and landing-page conditions	Early hook, CTR, landing-page and trial-start signals. No winner yet
12–18	Review trial quality, daily planning and activation	Do low-cost trial starts become repeat planners?
19–24	Iterate the strongest concept, one headline or product visual change at a time	A controlled creative iteration
25–30	Consolidate results and shift spend cautiously toward the best activated-trial economics	A clear note of what's supported, what's directional and what needs more data

Decision rule. Agree minimum spend and event volume before launch. If the evidence can't separate the variants, I'd call it inconclusive and keep learning, rather than force a winner.

What I expect to happen. I believe The Math wins attention and the cleanest trials, The Finish Line pulls fewer clicks but stickier planners, and The Founder's Day lands somewhere in between. I'd be delighted to be proven wrong. That's what the test is for.

Measurement framework

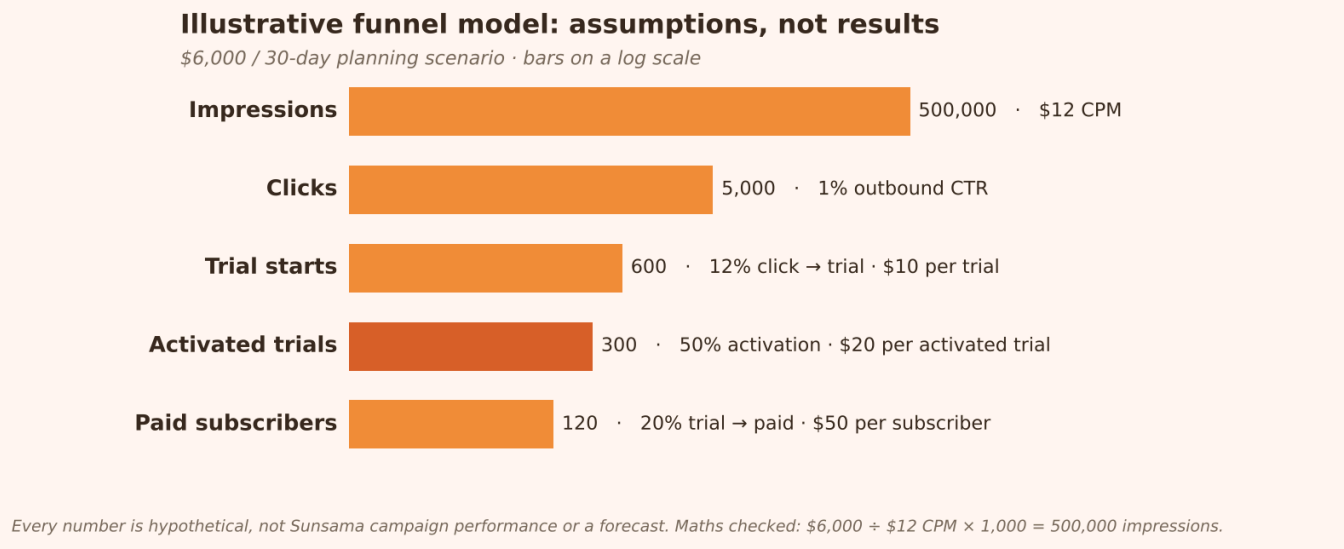
From my experience, a cheap trial is the most flattering number on a dashboard and the least honest. So the KPIs follow the habit, not the click.

Level	Metric	Why it matters
Business outcome	Cost per paid subscriber; paid conversion; early retention where available	Measures whether acquisition creates customers, not just traffic
Leading quality metric	Cost per activated trial	Balances acquisition cost with evidence of a forming habit

Level	Metric	Why it matters
Activation definition (proposed)	At least 3 daily plans completed in the first 7 days of trial	A testable proxy for repeat behaviour; not an official Sunsama benchmark
Funnel diagnostics	CPM, outbound CTR, landing-page view rate, trial-start rate, trial cost	Shows where attention or intent is lost
Product engagement	Daily-plan completion, return planning, shutdown ritual use	Separates curiosity from a real habit

Illustrative funnel model

Every number below is hypothetical. None is Sunsama campaign performance or a forecast.



Stage	Assumption	Read
Spend	$6,000	Planning budget scenario
CPM	$12	→ 500,000 impressions
Outbound CTR	1%	→ 5,000 clicks
Click → trial	12%	→ 600 trial starts
Trial → activation	50%	→ 300 activated trials
Trial → paid	20%	→ 120 paid subscribers
Cost per trial	$10	$6,000 ÷ 600

Cost per activated trial	$20	$6,000 ÷ 300
Cost per paid subscriber	$50	$6,000 ÷ 120

Pricing and payback sanity check. At an illustrative $50 acquisition cost, the $22 monthly plan takes about 2.3 months of gross revenue to match it. The $204 annual plan, billed upfront, exceeds $50 at purchase. Neither is contribution-margin payback or LTV:CAC: fees, refunds, taxes, support, churn, retention and plan mix aren't modelled. These assumptions need real campaign data before they can support a budget decision.

Failure metrics and learning

Here's where I believe things are most likely to break, and what I'd check before anyone panics.

Signal	What it might mean	What I'd do next
High CTR, low landing-page views or trial starts	A curiosity hook, slow page, message mismatch or tracking issue	Check load speed, promise continuity, CTA and tracking before rewriting everything
Cheap trial starts, weak activation	The ad attracted interest, not people who need daily planning, or onboarding is unclear	Review source quality and first-session friction; optimise to activation, not cheap signups
Good activation, weak paid conversion	Users try the routine but don't see enough ongoing value, or the price or plan fit is wrong	Inspect onboarding, value demonstration, objection handling and pricing-page behaviour
Strong clicks, weak return use	The creative promise is stronger than the habit the product builds	Review the first-week experience; don't scale on top-of-funnel results alone
One creative wins CTR but loses on activated-trial cost	Attention isn't turning into qualified use	Trust the quality metric; keep CTR as a diagnostic, not the verdict

Questions I'd want answered at day 30

- Which problem framing generated trials that came back to plan?
- Did the demo make Sunsama's mechanism clear in the first few seconds?
- Where did the funnel lose people: click, trial, activation or paid?
- Did the shutdown ritual make the value tangible, or did the workload math do more of the work?
- What didn't the test have enough evidence to answer?

Risks and limitations

The biggest risk I see isn't a weak ad. It's a polished ad that promises a calmer life than one trial can deliver.

- **Speculative work.** Not commissioned, approved or run by Sunsama. No media spend, live test or customer interview is claimed.
- **Survey limits.** Sunsama's well-being report is brand-published and its respondents aren't necessarily representative. Correlation isn't causation.
- **Ad Library and audit limits.** Screenshots show visible creative, not spend, delivery, audience, conversion or profitability. The competitive review is directional, not a systematic spend audit.
- **Assumptions everywhere.** Daniel, the 6 + 9 hour example, the $6,000 budget, the funnel inputs and the activation definition are all assumptions or proposals, never Sunsama data or official metrics.
- **Product and UI.** Confirm current feature names and interface before production, and validate tracking events with product analytics.

Final recommendation

Test all three ads against each other. Each bets on a different reason founders might care:

- **The Founder's Day:** I want control back.
- **The Math:** I need a plan that actually fits.
- **The Finish Line:** I want to stop at a time I choose.

The Math is my lead hypothesis, because it makes the capacity problem concrete and gives the product a clear job in the frame. The other two are challengers testing identity and emotional closure.

Priority	Action
Build	Produce the three statics with accurate Sunsama UI, restrained brand colours and one clear message each
Test	Compare them under consistent audience, offer and landing-page conditions
Judge quality	Cost per activated trial as the leading KPI; cost per paid subscriber as the business KPI
Diagnose	Use funnel metrics to find whether the issue is the hook, landing page, activation or paid conversion
Iterate	Refine the winner one variable at a time. Consider creator-led execution later, with a genuine Sunsama user

Priority	Action
Report honestly	Separate observed results from hypotheses and inconclusive outcomes. The funnel is a planning model, not a forecast

Founders already know how to run a company. I believe Sunsama can help them run the day too. After all, Slack is never going to tell you you're done for the day. **Sunsama will.**

References

Survey figures carry the Sunsama report's sample limits. Funnel numbers and the budget are scenario assumptions.

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